

The Northern Bulletin

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FEATURES

Whole-Grain Vegan Carrot Cake Loaf with Lemon Glaze

Angela Liddon (Oh She Glows) · Oh She Glows

A carrot cake loaf that's wholesome enough to enjoy for breakfast?! Yes please! Spiced with cinnamon, vanilla, and ginger, this beauty will fill your house with a delicious scent as it bakes. The loaf is naturally sweetened with maple syrup, and a lemon-cashew-coconut glaze gives the whole thing a fresh, zingy kick.

Growing up, I was always taking pictures. Of everything. My love affair started with a classic pink Polaroid camera and I would save up my allowance to buy new film.

Once I got my first point and shoot digital camera, I rarely left home without it. My family would always teasingly call me, 'the little tourist' because I took pictures of EVERYTHING...every moment...everyone...nothing could escape my wrath!

I never expected that my love for photography would blossom into a real hobby in my adult life. Eric bought a Canon DSLR back in 2007 and I was so intimidated by it, I didn't start using it for my blog photos for over two years! Over time, he was able to convince me (and show me) the difference a professional camera (and lens) could make in a photo with the right knowledge.

So why all this camera talk? Well, after my carrot loaf shoot yesterday it really hit me how much I love food photography. Nothing is better than looking on the camera screen and getting excited by the shots.

Ok, ok, it also helped that I took a nibble of this loaf and it tasted great!

I kept telling myself, do not eat the slice, do not eat the slice ...and then I was like 'forget that' and I took a bite! I think it gives the picture more character anyways. ;)

If your hesitant about cake for breakfast, maybe try my Heavenly Carrot Cake Baked Oatmeal or my Oh Mega Carrot Cake Breakfast Cookies — they won't disappoint!

Featuring all new, protein-packed salads, hearty toppers, flavour boosters, and dressings you'll want to drink, my new cookbook will transform the way you think about salads. Oh, and be sure to flip to the back for a surprise dessert chapter!

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Whole-Grain Carrot Cake Loaf with Lemon Glaze

Vegan, refined sugar-free, soy-free

★★★★★ 4.8 from 9 reviews

Yield 10 slices, plus 1/2 cup + 2 tbsp (155 mL) glaze

Prep time 20 minutes

Cook time 45 minutes

Total time 1 hour, 5 minutes

A carrot cake loaf that's wholesome enough to enjoy for breakfast?! Yes please! Spiced with cinnamon, vanilla, and ginger, this beauty will fill your house with a delicious scent as it bakes. The loaf is naturally sweetened with maple syrup, and a lemon-cashew-coconut glaze gives the whole thing a fresh, zingy kick. This recipe is a revamp of my 2011 carrot cake loaf, which was originally adapted from Sweet Freedom.

For the loaf:

1 1/2 cups (185 g) finely grated peeled carrot *

1 tablespoon (7 g) ground flax seed

1/2 cup plus 1 tablespoon (140 mL) pure maple syrup

3/4 cup (185 mL) almond milk or other plant milk

1/3 cup (80 mL) grapeseed oil or melted coconut oil **

1 1/2 teaspoons pure vanilla extract

1 teaspoon apple cider vinegar

2 teaspoons ground cinnamon

1 teaspoon ground ginger

2 teaspoons baking powder

1/2 teaspoon baking soda

1/2 teaspoon fine sea salt

1 1/2 cups (230 g) whole-grain spelt flour ***

1 cup (100 g) walnuts, chopped

For the glaze:

1/4 cup (60 mL) raw cashew butter

1/4 cup (60 mL) full-fat coconut cream, at room temperature

2 tablespoons (30 mL) pure maple syrup, at room temperature

1 tablespoon (15 mL) fresh lemon zest, or to taste

Dash fine sea salt

Preheat the oven to 350°F (180°C) and line a lightly oiled 8x4-inch loaf pan with parchment paper.

In a large bowl, mix the grated carrot, ground flax, maple

Mastering French Verb Conjugation: Common Verbs Ending in -Er, -Ir And -Re

Thomas Devlin · Babbel Tech Blog

One of the most exciting parts of your language journey is the very beginning, when it feels like the world is open to you. You spend time imagining yourself sitting on the French Riviera, and confidently ordering a croissant at a bakery. Then, that vision becomes cloudy as you come to think about your more immediate future: learning grammar rules and (gulp...) French verb conjugation. But don't let that ruin your fun! Learning to conjugate a French verb isn't as hard as you might think, especially because there are some predictable rules and conjugation patterns that will help you with conquer hundreds of verbs easily.

Mastering French conjugation of regular -ir, -er, and -re verbs is essential for fluency in the French language. In this comprehensive guide, we'll walk you through the process of conjugating these verb groups in the present, past (passe compose), future, and imperfect. There are irregular verbs you'll also need to memorize — pouvoir, aller, avoir, être, etc. — but working on these rules is a great first step.

French Conjugation of -Ir Verbs

Starting with -ir, we'll walk you through the conjugations using the verb infinitive finir ("to finish"), but other verbs including nourrir (definition: "to feed"), choisir ("to choose") and partir ("to leave") follow the same pattern.

Present -ir

je finis ("I finish") nous finissons ("we finish")
tu finis ("you finish") vous finissez ("you finish")
il/elle/on finit ("he/she/one finishes") ils/elles finissent ("they finish")

Past -ir

The past tense works a bit differently than the present tense in French. Here, all of the -ir verb endings are replaced with the same thing: -i. To distinguish between them, the verb avoir changes to the present tense.

j'ai fini ("I finished") nous avons fini ("we finished")
tu as fini ("you finished") vous avez fini ("you finished")
il/elle/on a fini ("he/she/one finished") ils/elles ont fini ("they finished")

Future -ir

je finirai ("I will finish") nous finirons ("we will finish")
tu finiras ("you will finish") vous finirez ("you will finish")
il/elle/on finira ("he/she/one will finish") ils/elles finiront ("they will finish")

Imperfect -ir

L'imparfait in French is used to refer to actions that were repeated or ongoing in the past.

je finissais ("I used to finish") nous finissions ("we used to finish")
tu finissais ("you used to finish") vous finissiez ("you used to finish")
il/elle/on finissait ("he/she/one used to finish") ils/elles finissaient ("they used to finish")

Conjugating -ER Verbs

Next up we have regular verbs that end in -er, using parler ("to speak") as our main example. Other common -er verbs include chercher ("to search"), étudier ("to study") and aimer ("to love/like"). Now, let's look at the correct way to use these verb forms.

Present -er

je parle ("I speak") nous parlons ("we speak")
tu parles ("you speak") vous parlez ("you speak")
il/elle/on parle ("he/she/one speaks") ils/elles parlent ("they speak")

Past -er

Just like with the -ir verbs, here the same ending is added, with -er replaced by é. Pro tip: You'll need to add and conjugate avoir in a way that reflects the subject of the sentence. See the conjugation table below for examples.

j'ai parlé ("I spoke") nous avons parlé ("we spoke")
tu as parlé ("you spoke") vous avez parlé ("you spoke")
il/elle/on a parlé ("he/she/one spoke") ils/elles ont parlé ("they spoke")

Future -er

je parlerai ("I will speak") nous parlerons ("we will speak")
tu parleras ("you will speak") vous parlerez ("you will speak")
il/elle/on parlera ("he/she/one will speak") ils/elles parleront ("they will speak")

Imperfect -er

je parlais ("I used to speak") nous parlions ("we used to speak")
tu parlais ("you used to speak") vous parliez ("you used to speak")
il/elle/on parlait ("he/she/one used to speak") ils/elles parlaient ("they used to speak")

Learn How to Conjugate -Re Verbs

Vancouver's first supertall skyscraper informed by "ancient glass sea sponge reefs"

Ben Dreith · Dezeen Architecture

Local studio Henriquez Partners Architects has designed a trio of skyscrapers in Vancouver, Canada, including the city's first supertall skyscraper.

Part of the larger Georgia & Abbott development for developer Holborn Group, the trio of skyscrapers set to be built in the middle of the dense Canadian city will be anchored by a 1,033-foot-tall (314 metre-tall) skyscraper.

When completed, 595 West Georgia Street will be the first supertall skyscraper in the city – defined as a building exceeding 984 feet (300 metres).

It will be wrapped in a steel exoskeleton covered in white GFRP panelling, with highly translucent spans of glass covering the entirety.

Henriquez Partners Architects has designed Vancouver's first supertall skyscraper

According to the studio, the design was based on the appearance of sea sponge reefs, with the studio hoping the skyscraper will play a positive role in the city's environment – as sea sponges do in the ocean.

"The architectural expression of the project tells a story that is unique to British Columbia and inspired by rare and ancient glass sea sponge reefs – living structures found off the BC coast that demonstrate strength and adaptability," said Henriquez Partners Architects.

"This natural metaphor is expressed not only in distinct silhouettes and the sculptural form of its tallest tower, but in their environmental performance towards a net-zero carbon operation."

At its top, the supertall skyscraper will be capped with a massive atrium holding a tree-filled public element, accessible by the public.

It has a form and facade pattern informed by sea glass sponges

The other two skyscrapers in the complex, which will rise from the same podium, will be 783 feet (237 metres) and 889 feet tall (271 metres).

The contemporary podium will incorporate the facade of the 1926 Randall Building, following Vancouver's heritage preservation principles.

Restaurants, cafe and other retail elements will be accessible from a plaza set between the skyscrapers, with a separate rounded structure holding hospitality elements. Renderings show this volume painted with a mural that appears to reference First Nations art motifs.

The three towers form a plaza on a block in Downtown Vancouver

In line with social housing requirements, the development includes a third building, further east. According to the studio, this 402-foot-tall (122 metres tall) structure will be contain social housing along with a gallery dedicated to First Nations art.

Its eight storey podium will have a brick-clad facade, while the setback 30-storey tower above will be more contemporary

Read:

Canada's tallest skyscraper becomes first in country above 100 storeys

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The studio said that the project was meant to bring further density into the expensive metropolis.

"This transformative project will serve as a major economic catalyst for downtown Vancouver, creating thousands of construction and permanent jobs," said the studio.

"By bringing a critical mass of residents, workers, and visitors into the core, the project will contribute to the creation of a more vibrant, welcoming, and safer downtown."

A fourth building will be constructed to fulfil social housing commitments

Georgia & Abbott recently received "unanimous" support from the powerful Urban Design Panel of the City of Vancouver, it will move to approvals from Public Hearing and City Council Approval this summer.

The project could be read as a response to current developments in Toronto, which include the country's tallest building, nearing completion, and other in-progress supertall skyscrapers such as one by Foster + Partners.

The images are courtesy of Henriquez Partners Architects/Holburn Group.

The post Vancouver's first supertall skyscraper informed by "ancient glass sea sponge reefs" appeared first on Dezeen.

TIMM Architecture fronts House of Iron Doors with weathered steel shutters

Jon Astbury · Dezeen Architecture

Georgian studio TIMM Architecture has completed House of Iron Doors, a home on the outskirts of Tbilisi that features an openable facade of perforated weathered steel shutters.

TIMM Architecture aimed to transform the aesthetic of high fences and walls of man homes in the neighbourhood into “an architectural experience rather than a defensive barrier” for this house in the village of Okrokana.

TIMM Architecture has created a house in Georgia

“The project began with a simple observation: in many suburban contexts the wall becomes the most dominant architectural element, while the house itself disappears behind it,” the studio told Dezeen.

“Exploring the relationship between wall, facade and garden led to a key question: what if the perimeter wall itself became architecture?”

It is fronted by weathered steel shutters

House of Iron Doors sits slightly raised above ground level, with an L-shaped plan that hugs a rear garden and is buffered from the street behind a strip of planting.

The street-facing section of this volume has been almost entirely given over to a large, glazed living area, which the facade’s shutters allow to be either completely open or closed, with light filtering in through small circular perforations.

There is a large glazed living area

Opposite, sliding glass doors open the living area and the adjacent dining room onto the central courtyard, facing a wall of weathered steel covered in metal mesh to support climbing plants.

“When the doors are fully opened, the house behaves almost like a pavilion where interior and exterior merge into a continuous living environment,” said the studio.

“The spatial atmosphere changes depending on the position of the facade panels: when closed, the house feels protective and introspective; when opened, it becomes transparent and outward-looking.”

The shutters filter light into the living room

TIMM Architecture chose weathering steel to create what it called an “infrastructural presence” on the street, with a monolithic appearance when the shutters are closed that is contrasted by the home’s minimal, largely monochromatic interiors.

The perpendicular wing of the home contains two storeys of bedrooms, while above the living area a swimming pool opens out onto a rooftop terrace via sliding glass doors.

Read:

Ten ways that architects used weathering steel in 2025

“Material selection was guided by the conceptual idea of the façade as both boundary and mechanism,” explained the studio. “Weathered steel was chosen for the operable doors because it expresses solidity, durability and transformation.”

“Other materials are intentionally restrained and minimal, allowing the movement of the facade and the spatial relationships of the house to remain the primary architectural expression,” it continued.

The home features a courtyard

Beneath the home, a basement floor contains a garage accessed via a ramp at the front of the home, as well as a games room, utility and storage spaces.

Other projects that have recently incorporated large shutters include an office in Fujisawa City by Schemata Architects, which features a facade of operable corrugated metal shutters.

The post TIMM Architecture fronts House of Iron Doors with weathered steel shutters appeared first on Dezeen .

United upgraded the economy flight experience with this brilliant new seat design

Hunter Schwarz · Fast Company Design

Few sectors of the economy show the growing divide between the haves and have-nots more than the airline industry—which is increasingly catering to high-income fliers in an effort to squeeze as much revenue per available seat mile as possible. United Airlines, which just announced newly designed economy seats you can lie flat and sleep on, found a clever way to appeal to everyone by bringing the couch to coach.

This week, the airline announced what it calls “United Relax Row,” a row of three seats that transform into a single lie-flat space. The seats will begin appearing on United aircraft in 2027. Reaction online to the airline’s announcement was joyous.

“United built the product that everyone who has ever been on an airplane has wanted!” John Collison, president of the payments and financial services company Stripe, wrote on X.

[United Relax Row seats in action. Photo: United]

How does the Relax Row work?

The Relax Row is designed with armrests that go up all the way and adjustable leg rests that fold up to 90 degrees, giving fliers a wider flat surface to lie upon. United says booking the row will get you a custom-fitted mattress pad to go with the seats, plus blankets, extra pillows, and a plush toy for kids. The company plans to offer as many as 12 of these Relax Row sections per plane and roll them out to more than 200 aircraft by 2030.

Premium customers already have the option to lie down during long flights in United’s Polaris business class seating, which comes with a custom Saks Fifth Avenue sleep set. In 2021, the German air carrier Lufthansa allowed customers to pay extra to book a row of three economy seats to themselves and get a mattress topper for their flight.

United channeled these trends into its new cabin design. By putting the new seats in economy and pitching it to customers as “premium for all,” the airline can characterize the move as one that’s looking out for everyone in the back of the plane and not just those in first class—while still increasing profit margins.

The company is the first North American airline to offer lie-down coach seating, and the company says the option is geared toward families with young kids, couples, and solo travelers who want more space.

[Photo: United]

Already, United offers complimentary kids meals, a Sesame Street-branded travel kit for children, and free family seating to seat families together. Giving customers with young kids the option to let them sleep soundly on a flat surface

during a long-haul flight could further curry favor with families.

Why better economy seating is good for business

As fuel costs rise and lower-income customers pressured by years of inflation make up a smaller share of revenue, the K-shaped economic recovery from the COVID pandemic is showing up in the design of airline cabins in other ways, too.

Southwest Airlines added skinnier seats that weigh less, while Frontier Airlines made bigger seats with extra cushions and wider armrests to upsell its budget flights. For United, the second-biggest airline by revenue behind Delta Air Lines, its challenge is the premiumization of an already premium brand.

[Photo: United]

United said Tuesday that new cabin designs will have more premium seating and less economy seating. Chief commercial officer Andrew Nocella explained on the company’s January earnings call that premium cabin revenue was up about 11% year over year, while basic economy revenue was down 5%.

Finally, an airline is offering a lie-down, long-haul flight option for economy fliers. But for United, it’s about more than just comfort. The new seats have the potential to make the back of the plane pricier for fliers who want more space, and more profitable for the airline’s bottom line.

Perfect Little Pumpkin Cookies with Spiced Buttercream

Angela Liddon (Oh She Glows) · Oh She Glows

Hey everyone, I hope you are doing well! I'm popping in with a fun fall-inspired cookie recipe today that's been on repeat in this house.

First, I want to thank you all so much for your support for Oh She Glows for Dinner! I'm immensely grateful for each and every one of you who believe in me and in what I create. It's sounding like cozy, plant-based meals to enjoy at home is a theme you're really eager for, and hearing this makes me so happy because this book was almost the end of little 'ol me...hah ;) jk. Well, it was my biggest challenge to date, but sooo worth it and I'm thrilled with how it all came together. Now that I get to cook from this book in my own kitchen, it's pretty darn special. I can't wait for you to be able to do so as well.

Okay, now it's time to ring in the fall season with a brand-new, lightly spiced, and completely addictive frosted pumpkin cookie.

Sending you all my love and good vibes for the new season ahead!

Featuring all new, protein-packed salads, hearty toppers, flavour boosters, and dressings you'll want to drink, my new cookbook will transform the way you think about salads. Oh, and be sure to flip to the back for a surprise dessert chapter!

Pre-Order Now

% OFF

Perfect Little Pumpkin Cookies with Spiced Buttercream

Vegan, soy-free

★★★★★ 4.8 from 17 reviews

Yield 20 cookies

Prep time 25 minutes

Cook time 13 minutes

Total time 38 minutes

Why hello there, beautiful pumpkin season! These lovely pumpkin cookies are lightly crispy around the edges, tender and chewy in the middle, and the perfect light-tasting base for my Fluffy Pumpkin Pie Spice Buttercream. My recipe tester, Nicole, says they are like "airy, pumpkin spiced clouds with a delightful outer shell to sink your teeth into!" If you aren't in the mood for frosting, and prefer a lightly sweet, wholesome-tasting cookie, they also taste great without the buttercream. You can use store bought pumpkin pie spice for convenience, or this recipe for Homemade Pumpkin Pie Spice Mix. In the Tips section, I've provided

sifted whole-grain spelt and all-purpose white flour swap options for the white/light spelt flour. Be sure to check them out before you begin as the flour substitutions aren't direct 1:1 swaps. This recipe is adapted from my Easy Vegan Sugar Cookies with Pink Frosting.

For the wet ingredients:

3 tablespoons (45 mL) grapeseed oil

3 tablespoons (45 mL) pure maple syrup

1/4 cup (60 mL) unsweetened pumpkin purée

2 tablespoons (30 mL) brown rice syrup

1 1/2 teaspoons ground flaxseed

1/2 teaspoon pure vanilla extract

For the dry ingredients:

3/4 cup plus 1 tablespoon (83 g) almond flour *

1 cup plus 1 tablespoon (127 g) white/light all-purpose spelt flour **

3 tablespoons (27 g) arrowroot starch

1/4 cup (60 g) natural cane sugar

1 teaspoon pumpkin pie spice

1/4 teaspoon fine sea salt

1/2 teaspoon baking soda

For the Fluffy Pumpkin Pie Spice Buttercream:

1/4 cup plus 2 tablespoons (75 g) soy-free vegan butter

1 1/2 cups (190 g) powdered icing sugar, sifted if necessary

1/2 teaspoon pumpkin pie spice

Pinch fine sea salt

Cinnamon or pumpkin pie spice, for garnish (optional)

Preheat the oven to 350°F (180°C) and line one extra-large baking sheet (or two medium-sized sheets) with parchment paper.

To a small bowl, add the wet ingredients: grapeseed oil, maple syrup, pumpkin purée, brown rice syrup, ground flax, and vanilla. Whisk until combined.

To a large bowl, add the dry ingredients: almond flour, spelt flour, arrowroot starch, cane sugar, pumpkin pie spice, salt, and baking soda. Whisk until combined.

Pour the wet mixture over the dry mixture (being sure to scoop all of the wet ingredients stuck to the sides of the

Who is the Kimwolf Botmaster “Dort”?

Brian Krebs · Krebs on Security

In early January 2026, KrebsOnSecurity revealed how a security researcher disclosed a vulnerability that was used to build Kimwolf, the world's largest and most disruptive botnet. Since then, the person in control of Kimwolf — who goes by the handle “Dort” — has coordinated a barrage of distributed denial-of-service (DDoS), doxing and email flooding attacks against the researcher and this author, and more recently caused a SWAT team to be sent to the researcher's home. This post examines what is knowable about Dort based on public information.

A public “dox” created in 2020 asserted Dort was a teenager from Canada (DOB August 2003) who used the aliases “CPacket” and “M1ce.” A search on the username CPacket at the open source intelligence platform OSINT Industries finds a GitHub account under the names Dort and CPacket that was created in 2017 using the email address jay.miner232@gmail.com.

Image: osint.industries.

The cyber intelligence firm Intel 471 says jay.miner232@gmail.com was used between 2015 and 2019 to create accounts at multiple cybercrime forums, including Nulled (username “Uubuntuu”) and Cracked (user “Dorted”); Intel 471 reports that both of these accounts were created from the same Internet address at Rogers Canada (99.241.112.24).

Dort was an extremely active player in the Microsoft game Minecraft who gained notoriety for their “Dortware” software that helped players cheat. But somewhere along the way, Dort graduated from hacking Minecraft games to enabling far more serious crimes.

Dort also used the nickname DortDev, an identity that was active in March 2022 on the chat server for the prolific cybercrime group known as LAPSUS\$. Dort peddled a service for registering temporary email addresses, as well as “Dortsolver,” code that could bypass various CAPTCHA services designed to prevent automated account abuse. Both of these offerings were advertised in 2022 on SIM Land, a Telegram channel dedicated to SIM-swapping and account takeover activity.

The cyber intelligence firm Flashpoint indexed 2022 posts on SIM Land by Dort that show this person developed the disposable email and CAPTCHA bypass services with the help of another hacker who went by the handle “Qoft.”

“I legit just work with Jacob,” Qoft said in 2022 in reply to another user, referring to their exclusive business partner Dort. In the same conversation, Qoft bragged that the two had stolen more than \$250,000 worth of Microsoft Xbox Game Pass accounts by developing a program that mass-created Game Pass identities using stolen payment card data.

Who is the Jacob that Qoft referred to as their business partner? The breach tracking service Constella Intelligence finds the password used by jay.miner232@gmail.com was reused by just one other email address: jacobbutler803@gmail.com. Recall that the 2020 dox of Dort said their date of birth was August 2003 (8/03).

Searching this email address at DomainTools.com reveals it was used in 2015 to register several Minecraft-themed domains, all assigned to a Jacob Butler in Ottawa, Canada and to the Ottawa phone number 613-909-9727.

Constella Intelligence finds jacobbutler803@gmail.com was used to register an account on the hacker forum Nulled in 2016, as well as the account name “M1CE” on Minecraft. Pivoting off the password used by their Nulled account shows it was shared by the email addresses j.a.y.m.iner232@gmail.com and jbutl3@ocdsb.ca, the latter being an address at a domain for the Ottawa-Carleton District School Board.

Data indexed by the breach tracking service Spycloud suggests that at one point Jacob Butler shared a computer with his mother and a sibling, which might explain why their email accounts were connected to the password “jacob-plugs.” Neither Jacob nor any of the other Butler household members responded to requests for comment.

The open source intelligence service Epieos finds jacobbutler803@gmail.com created the GitHub account “MemeClient.” Meanwhile, Flashpoint indexed a deleted anonymous Pastebin.com post from 2017 declaring that MemeClient was the creation of a user named CPacket — one of Dort's early monikers.

Why is Dort so mad? On January 2, KrebsOnSecurity published The Kimwolf Botnet is Stalking Your Local Network, which explored research into the botnet by Benjamin Brundage, founder of the proxy tracking service Synthient. Brundage figured out that the Kimwolf botmasters were exploiting a little-known weakness in residential proxy services to infect poorly-defended devices — like TV boxes and digital photo frames — plugged into the internal, private networks of proxy endpoints.

By the time that story went live, most of the vulnerable proxy providers had been notified by Brundage and had fixed the weaknesses in their systems. That vulnerability remediation process massively slowed Kimwolf's ability to spread, and within hours of the story's publication Dort created a Discord server in my name that began publishing personal information about and violent threats against Brundage, Yours Truly, and others.

Dort and friends incriminating themselves by planning swatting attacks in a public Discord server.

Last week, Dort and friends used that same Discord server (then named “Krebs's Koinbase Kallars”) to threaten a swatting attack against Brundage, again posting his home address and personal information. Brundage told KrebsOn-

Is Banyan Tree Mayakoba Worth It? Our Full Review

Kristin Addis · Be My Travel Muse

Banyan Tree Mayakoba is one of those resorts where you feel immersed in nature, far away from any parties or crowds, and that's exactly the point. It hits you with a big arrival moment at a dramatic lobby, then quietly pulls you into a slower rhythm almost immediately.

If you're looking for a place that feels private, green, and genuinely restful, especially when traveling with kids, this one stands out in a way that's hard to replicate elsewhere in the Riviera Maya.

Booking Through Us and Banyan Tree Benefits

When you book Banyan Tree Mayakoba through Muse Bespoke Escapes, you receive preferred partner benefits that are simple but meaningful and tend to make the stay feel easier rather than more complicated.

- ☑ Daily breakfast for two
- ☑ Resort credit to use on dining or spa treatments
- ↑ Room upgrade on arrival when available
- 🕒 Early check-in and late checkout when possible
- ☑ Priority VIP treatment at the resort

There's no script or upsell attached to this. Things just tend to flow better, and staff are aware you're arriving through a preferred channel.

Get in touch to book.

Arrival and Overall Feel

You don't walk into Banyan Tree so much as you're eased into it. Located around 45 minutes from Cancun airport, just past the Ruta de Cenotes towards Playa del Carmen, Mayakoba is a serene getaway tucked behind several miles of mangrove. Check-in happens calmly, seated, and without a lot of back and forth. From there, everything is water, greenery, and quiet pathways.

The resort is built around lagoons and mangroves, so even moving from place to place feels peaceful. You hear birds constantly. Mornings are especially calm, and evenings feel unhurried.

Despite being part of the larger Mayakoba complex, Banyan Tree feels entirely separate once you're inside, yet you can easily take a duffy boat or golf cart to any of the other resorts and their restaurants as well – Rosewood Mayakoba, Fairmont Mayakoba, and soon to be the Alila Mayakoba.

The Villas and Living Space

Every guest stays in a private villa with its own pool, and that single detail shapes the entire experience.

Our villa — one of the newly renovated 3 bedroom villas — felt more like a small residence than a hotel room. High ceilings, lots of space, and a layout that made sense for spending real time there. There was an indoor living area, outdoor space, and a pool that felt secluded rather than on display.

There were 4 bathrooms, the main with a deep soaking tub and plenty of room to spread out. It was the kind of space you actually want to use, not just pass through.

Traveling with a child, this setup made everything easier. Naps didn't require tiptoeing around. Early bedtimes didn't mean the night was over for us. We could order room service, swim outside, and still feel relaxed.

Getting Around the Resort

The resort is spread out, but moving around never felt inconvenient. You get around by bike or boat, and both quickly become part of the rhythm of the stay rather than something to manage. Our toddler loved both the golf carts and the boat, so it was all part of the experience for him.

Boat rides are slow and quiet. Bikes are easy and flat, and kids tend to love them. If you don't feel like moving at all, staff are quick to come get you. Everyone and everything you need is just a call or Whatsapp message away.

Nothing about the layout feels rushed or chaotic.

Pools, Beach, and Outdoor Time

The beach area is calm and understated, on a white sand beach with perfectly calm waters that are baby blue hued. No loud music, no packed loungers, and no pressure to claim a spot early. It's a place where people actually read books and stay a while. It was our favorite spot at the whole resort.

The shared pool areas are lovely, but having a private pool often meant we didn't feel the need to leave our villa unless we wanted to.

This setup works especially well for families with younger kids. There's room to splash, play, and relax without constantly packing up and moving locations.

Food and Dining

Food at Banyan Tree Mayakoba is consistently good, but what stood out more than anything was how unique it felt.

Our favorite experience was dining at Saffron, the Thai restaurant with decks right on the water (both with and without rails depending on what makes you most comfortable with little kids). It was delicious and such a fun experience dining right on the water while looking at sea turtles and fish.

The breakfast (we especially loved the beach club!), Italian restaurant, cello, and room service were great, too.

This brilliant browser tool purposely makes AI chatbots worse

Grace Snelling · Fast Company Design

A new browser extension just debuted that's designed to be used in tandem with an AI chatbot. Its goal is to make the experience worse.

"Are you concerned that you or your loved ones might be experiencing a LLM-induced psychosis? Or participating in a massive de-skilling event? Or outsourcing cognitive and emotional functions to auto-complete?" designer Sam Lavigne asks in a YouTube video introducing his new product. "Then you should install 'Slow LLM' on your computer."

[Image: Slow LLM]

Lavigne is an assistant professor of synthetic media and algorithmic justice at Parsons School of Design, as well as an artist and web designer. Slow LLM is his latest creation, and its entire purpose is to make using AI chatbots as excruciating as possible. Whereas ChatGPT might answer a simple prompt such as "What day is it?" in a matter of milliseconds, Slow LLM intervenes to stretch that out to the nails-on-a-chalkboard pace of 30 seconds or more.

Slow LLM is a small yet eye-catching act of digital protest against the proliferation of AI tools, and it joins a growing catalog of similar efforts like "Your AI slop bores me," a human-powered chatbot, and "Slop Evader," a Chrome extension built to turn back the clock to the days before AI-generated search summaries.

[Image: Slow LLM]

Those behind these projects, which Lavigne describes as "tiny tools for digital sabotage," know that they're not exactly combating the wave of artificial intelligence and large language models. Instead, they're asking users to reconsider how they're using AI tools—and what they might be missing out on in the process.

Designing a tiny tool of digital rebellion

Lavigne is no stranger to creating tools of digital sabotage. His past projects have included "Slow Hot Computer," a website that does exactly what the name suggests; "Zoom Escaper," a tool to help you escape Zoom meetings by self-sabotaging your audio stream; and "The Good Life," an email service that sends you 225,000 emails from the Enron email archive in chronological order. For Lavigne, these sites are all about turning the mission of most web developers on its head by creating more friction rather than removing it.

In the case of Slow LLM, Lavigne explains: "Like many other people, I've been thinking a lot lately about the political, financial, ecological, and emotional effects of LLMs. I became interested in exploring ways to disrupt their usage, either as something that people might wish to do to themselves, or as a kindness to others."

He decided that, to achieve this goal, it would be best to take a softer approach—making LLMs worse, rather than blocking them altogether. In a matter of days, he pulled together Slow LLM.

The browser extension, available for Chrome and Firefox, currently works to stunt both OpenAI's ChatGPT and Anthropic's Claude. It functions like a football player intercepting a ball mid-pass. Typically, when a user chats with an LLM in a web browser, it sends that prompt to a server using a built-in JavaScript function named "fetch." Slow LLM replaces fetch with Lavigne's own version that buffers all network requests, making them appear to run at a trickle.

AI adoption feels effortless when it's fast, easy, and convenient. Slow LLM invites reluctant users to reconsider their choices while watching ChatGPT painstakingly thread together a response that they could have just Googled.

The Big and the Small

Tim Urban · Wait But Why

I have a surprise for you.

I'll tell you about it in a minute. First, let's have a little fun. Come with me.

I haven't told anyone this before, but I actually live in the fun room. I just gave you a tour of my house, where I spend a large portion of my life thinking about the size of things.

I have visitors in the fun room from time to time, but after a few minutes, they're usually pretty funned out and leave me to my crises. But one day, something unexpected happened.

It was 2013. Wait But Why was a few months old. And I got an email from someone named Philipp Dettmer. I was slightly unsettled by the pp and tt, but I decided to read what he had to say.

He explained that he lives in Germany where he makes animated educational videos about a lot of different things, kind of like Wait But Why but a different medium. I took a look at his YouTube page. It was named a random string of letters:

kurzgesagt

Apparently it means "In a Nutshell" in German, but I didn't know that at the time and was very close to being done with Philipp Dettmer for good when I decided to watch one of the videos.

It was delightful .

I watched another. And another. And then it hit me.

Philipp—this random man in Germany— also lives in the fun room.

The next day, we were on the phone. There was a lot to talk about. We decided we had to do something together, and we settled on adapting one of my early posts into a kurzgesagt video . 1

In the seven years since then, Philipp and I have become great friends, and I have not missed a kurzgesagt video since. Whenever Philipp and I get dinner, we head straight to the fun room to talk about the universe. And a few months ago, we decided to collaborate again. It was time to go public with the fun room.

At some point in our pasts, we had both become enamored with two fun room icons, Cary and Michael Huang, known on the internet as the Huang Twins. The twins do a lot of cool things , but it was their Scale of the Universe toy that we loved most.

Inspired by their work, we decided to go for it. We wanted to make the best size explorer we could imagine. We called it Universe in a Nutshell.

Of course, it took roughly 18 times longer than we thought it would. We brainstormed the interface for quite some time, and then Philipp, along with the incredible kurzgesagt team, dug into working on illustrations and animations, while I worked with the team on the written explainers.

Thousands of human hours later, the app is done. 250 objects, 30,000+ words of explanations and fun facts, just the right mood music, and what we think is a pretty great interface.

Here's how it works:

The app is a giant wall. The wall is impossibly large—large enough to fit full-sized galaxies on it. The wall is also impossibly high-resolution—hi-res enough to contain sharp images of subatomic particles.

I know it seems weird that I'm talking about it as if it's a real object, but I have a good reason: to get the full mind-blow effect, you have to realize what you're looking at. You're not moving forward and backward through a tunnel of objects—it just seems that way because your brain will refuse to accept the insanity of the actual sizes you're seeing. By reminding yourself again and again that all of these objects are "painted" on the same 2D wall, you'll hopefully experience some fun mind-bending moments.

The app looks like this:

And this:

And this:

And there are three ways to zoom:

You can tap any object for an explainer and fun facts. All of the facts you just read in the fun room are also in the app, along with a million other things. (The surprisingly-good-for-Wait-But-Why-illustrations from the fun room are the work of Kurzgesagt. Don't think this is some new normal.)

Three more things:

1) The app is \$3 in the US store, which, considering the fact that a magical infinite wall should really go for like \$2.5 million, is a huge steal.

2) If you like the app, please give it a rating or review. For example, here's my review:

3) This is V1 of the app. As we made the app, we had a constant side conversation going on about possibilities for V2, V3, and beyond. We're launching today, but this is just the beginning. We want this app to be a brain playground that just keeps getting better and better. And here's where you come in.

I met my AI twin—and now I’m in an existential crisis

Grace Snelling · Fast Company Design

Before I ever met Sam Kecici, I had already interviewed him on his career, his use of AI, and his thoughts on data privacy. In this case, “him” might be a loose word, depending on your definition—I had spoken not with Kecici himself, but with an AI chatbot that he designed to recall his memories, mimic his personality, and share his opinions.

Kecici is an ex-Amazon software engineer who, since August 2025, has been building an AI company called Sentience. The real Kecici, who I spoke to after interviewing his personal AI, describes Sentience as “the digital version of you, but with perfect memory.”

It’s a chatbot that uses your emails, Slack messages, Apple Notes, social media, and anywhere else that you might show up online to create a chatbot and assistant that understands the context of your life and mimics your tone, opinions, and writing quirks. As Kecici’s digital doppelganger explained it to me: “The long-term vision is a digital twin that can recall anything you’ve experienced, communicate in your voice, and eventually operate on your behalf.”

Sentience debuts to the public on March 26 after raising \$6.5 million in an initial seed round led by Bain Capital Ventures. It’s launching for free, but plans to add paid tiers in the coming weeks. Currently, it’s available as a desktop app, mobile app, and an embedded feature in Slack. In the future, though, Kecici says he wants Sentience to be able to “interact in all of the different applications you use,” from iMessage to WhatsApp and Microsoft Teams.

Having tested it for about a week, I can say that it’s the most natural-sounding chatbot I’ve ever talked to. It was able to almost uncannily mimic my writing quirks, predict my opinions on design news, and write its own articles from my perspective. Sentience feels like an inevitable next step in the evolution of AI assistants, where instead of a mass-market chatbot that caters to a generalized “you,” you get a personalized bot that knows almost everything about you—for better and for worse.

[Image: Sentience]

An AI designed to mimic you

As AI models have become exponentially more powerful in recent years, the concept of building digital twins has gained popularity. Last April, Stanford University researchers published a paper in which they used AI to build a “digital twin” of the part of the mouse brain that processes visual information, a breakthrough that they said could be applied to future research on the human brain.

Right now, the average consumer can use a variety of nascent tools to purportedly clone themselves as a means to be more productive. Sentience aims to marry personalization with the functions of a productivity platform, similar to something like Superhuman or Notion.

Kecici first began dreaming of a digital twin while working as the CTO of a software development company called Macro. After spending five years in the position, he started to feel like “a glorified information router.”

“I was no longer a human being. I was just someone who shuttled information from one place to the next,” Kecici says. Sentience began to take shape in Kecici’s mind as a tool that bridges that gap. He wanted to build an AI that could perfectly remember everything he had ever created, researched, or written on his laptop, and also format that information to answer questions on his behalf.

[Image: Sentience]

Kecici bills his concept of a “digital twin” as a response to the big AI models—like ChatGPT and Claude—that have optimized their language responses based on vast amounts of generalized data. In order to appeal to the broadest user base, many of these tools have developed a standard tone that’s agreeable at best and obsequious at worst (in some cases, to users’ serious detriment). According to an October analysis from researchers at Harvard and Zurich’s Swiss Federal Institute of Technology, AI models are, on average, 50% more sycophantic than humans.

“I think the reason is because those models are optimized for keeping you engaged,” Kecici says. “ChatGPT is designed to literally keep you for the maximum amount of time. It turns out that if a language model is complimenting you all the time, then you’re going to use it more. But this is not fundamentally how humans work.”

Unlike these bigger models, he explains, Sentience is trained almost exclusively to parse through and digest data about you, the user.

How Sentience is designed to remember like a human brain

Sentience is powered by an amalgamation of various foundational models. Claude is the main AI powering the program, but it also incorporates other tools like Gemini Flash for heftier queries and WhisperX for transcription. These components are like the bones and muscles powering Sentience—but its custom memory layer is the brain.

Constructing Sentience’s communication style started with removing what Kecici calls “the AI slop factor.” Essentially, this stage looked like repeated prompting to strip away the base models’ tendencies toward people pleasing, as well as other AI giveaways like overuse of the em dash and choppy sentence structures. Then, Kecici built a memory layer for Sentience that’s intended to mimic human cognition as closely as possible.

First, Sentience takes in as many inputs from a user’s digital life as possible (depending on what the user grants access to), from Uber receipts to Reddit deep dives, programming projects, and email history. Then it categorizes that data into short-term and long-term memories; short-term being whatever the user is currently working on, and long-term

Construction material costs set to rise if Strait of Hormuz blockade continues

Lizzie Crook · Dezeen Architecture

The continued blockade of the Strait of Hormuz could push up prices of building materials, including steel and cement, a study by global construction consultant Linesight has warned.

If disruption continues in the Strait of Hormuz – a narrow waterway between Iran and the UAE – the construction industry should prepare for higher prices for aluminium, steel, copper and cement, the report states.

Iran is currently restricting access to the waterway used to ship a fifth of the world's oil supply following US and Israeli strikes on the country creating a bottleneck for the oil and gas trade.

The blockade is pushing energy and shipping costs higher, which is expected to have a knock-on effect on the production and transport costs of construction materials.

According to Linesight, this crisis exacerbates the ongoing impact of conflict in the region, including disruption to the Red Sea-Suez trade route.

“Recent disruption is not about a single event, it is the accumulation of energy volatility, constrained logistics and geopolitical risk across multiple routes,” said Linesight's vice president Derek McNamara in the report.

Blockade could have greatest impact on aluminium

In its analysis, Linesight said the chokepoint could have an especially large impact on the cost of aluminium, the second most widely used metal in construction after steel.

This is largely due to Gulf countries producing approximately nine per cent of the global supply, predominantly for export, while relying on imports of bauxite and alumina to produce it.

Suspended gas supplies also caused a smelter used to make aluminium in Qatar to stop operations on 3 March, while the Aluminium Bahrain smelter has also halted shipping, according to the report.

Steel is also likely to be impacted by escalating energy prices and tighter supply, as steelmaking is energy-intensive and furnaces rely heavily on fuels such as gas.

Read:

Over 40,000 civilian buildings in Iran reportedly damaged in ongoing war

Similarly, rising energy costs are feeding through into higher cement production costs due to the material's energy-hungry manufacturing process. Cement is also heavy to transport, meaning an increase in shipping costs from

disrupted and diverted routes is expected to drive the material's price up further.

“A short-lived disruption may be absorbed, but a prolonged period of elevated energy and freight costs would reset cement price baselines across regions,” the report states.

While the Gulf region doesn't produce much copper, it is a leading supplier of sulphur, a byproduct of oil and gas production that is essential for sulphuric acid used in copper ore processing.

Linesight said the war has put “nearly half of global sulphur exports at risk”, meaning copper smelters face potential shortages of acid, hastening the rise of copper prices.

US-Israeli strikes have damaged over 40,000 civilian buildings

In a report by the BBC, the effective closure of the Strait of Hormuz by Iran has hiked the price of a barrel of oil to above \$100 (£74.87) this morning.

The concerns in Linesight's report are echoed by UK building material supplier Travis Perkins, which has said it is considering raising prices.

“In the last week or so, we've had communications from various manufacturing suppliers of ours saying they're looking at energy surcharges or they're looking at price increases to counteract energy rises,” said Travis Perkins CEO Gavin Slark.

Read:

The current wave of US-Israeli strikes on Iran began on February 28, killing Iranian supreme leader Ali Khamenei. Iran has retaliated with missile and drone strikes on Israeli and US-allied countries and bases across the Middle East.

Analysis by the humanitarian group Iranian Red Crescent Society has found that 42,914 civilian buildings in Iran have been damaged by US-Israeli airstrikes. Iranian strikes have also caused damage to notable buildings across the Middle East.

The main image is courtesy of Shutterstock.

The post Construction material costs set to rise if Strait of Hormuz blockade continues appeared first on Dezeen.

While the Gulf region doesn't produce much copper, it is a leading supplier of sulphur, a byproduct of oil and gas production that is essential for sulphuric acid used in copper ore processing.

Lizzie Crook

Kimwolf Botnet Swamps Anonymity Network I2P

Brian Krebs · Krebs on Security

For the past week, the massive “Internet of Things” (IoT) botnet known as Kimwolf has been disrupting The Invisible Internet Project (I2P), a decentralized, encrypted communications network designed to anonymize and secure online communications. I2P users started reporting disruptions in the network around the same time the Kimwolf botmasters began relying on it to evade takedown attempts against the botnet’s control servers.

Kimwolf is a botnet that surfaced in late 2025 and quickly infected millions of systems, turning poorly secured IoT devices like TV streaming boxes, digital picture frames and routers into relays for malicious traffic and abnormally large distributed denial-of-service (DDoS) attacks.

I2P is a decentralized, privacy-focused network that allows people to communicate and share information anonymously.

“It works by routing data through multiple encrypted layers across volunteer-operated nodes, hiding both the sender’s and receiver’s locations,” the I2P website explains. “The result is a secure, censorship-resistant network designed for private websites, messaging, and data sharing.”

On February 3, I2P users began complaining on the organization’s GitHub page about tens of thousands of routers suddenly overwhelming the network, preventing existing users from communicating with legitimate nodes. Users reported a rapidly increasing number of new routers joining the network that were unable to transmit data, and that the mass influx of new systems had overwhelmed the network to the point where users could no longer connect.

I2P users complaining about service disruptions from a rapidly increasing number of routers suddenly swamping the network.

When one I2P user asked whether the network was under attack, another user replied, “Looks like it. My physical router freezes when the number of connections exceeds 60,000.”

A graph shared by I2P developers showing a marked drop in successful connections on the I2P network around the time the Kimwolf botnet started trying to use the network for fallback communications.

The same day that I2P users began noticing the outages, the individuals in control of Kimwolf posted to their Discord channel that they had accidentally disrupted I2P after attempting to join 700,000 Kimwolf-infected bots as nodes on the network.

The Kimwolf botmaster openly discusses what they are doing with the botnet in a Discord channel with my name on it.

Although Kimwolf is known as a potent weapon for launching DDoS attacks, the outages caused this week by some portion of the botnet attempting to join I2P are what’s known as a “Sybil attack,” a threat in peer-to-peer networks where a single entity can disrupt the system by creating, controlling, and operating a large number of fake, pseudonymous identities.

Indeed, the number of Kimwolf-infected routers that tried to join I2P this past week was many times the network’s normal size. I2P’s Wikipedia page says the network consists of roughly 55,000 computers distributed throughout the world, with each participant acting as both a router (to relay traffic) and a client.

However, Lance James, founder of the New York City based cybersecurity consultancy Unit 221B and the original founder of I2P, told KrebsOnSecurity the entire I2P network now consists of between 15,000 and 20,000 devices on any given day.

An I2P user posted this graph on Feb. 10, showing tens of thousands of routers — mostly from the United States — suddenly attempting to join the network.

Benjamin Brundage is founder of Synthient, a startup that tracks proxy services and was the first to document Kimwolf’s unique spreading techniques. Brundage said the Kimwolf operator(s) have been trying to build a command and control network that can’t easily be taken down by security companies and network operators that are working together to combat the spread of the botnet.

Brundage said the people in control of Kimwolf have been experimenting with using I2P and a similar anonymity network — Tor — as a backup command and control network, although there have been no reports of widespread disruptions in the Tor network recently.

“I don’t think their goal is to take I2P down,” he said. “It’s more they’re looking for an alternative to keep the botnet stable in the face of takedown attempts.”

The Kimwolf botnet created challenges for Cloudflare late last year when it began instructing millions of infected devices to use Cloudflare’s domain name system (DNS) settings, causing control domains associated with Kimwolf to repeatedly usurp Amazon, Apple, Google and Microsoft in Cloudflare’s public ranking of the most frequently requested websites.

James said the I2P network is still operating at about half of its normal capacity, and that a new release is rolling out which should bring some stability improvements over the next week for users.

Meanwhile, Brundage said the good news is Kimwolf’s overlords appear to have quite recently alienated some of their more competent developers and operators, leading to a rookie mistake this past week that caused the botnet’s overall numbers to drop by more than 600,000 infected systems.

class="wp-caption-text" An I2P user posted this graph on Feb.

BrianKrebs

Multiple Neom construction contracts cancelled

Amy Peacock · Dezeen Architecture

A trio of companies have announced the cancellation of contracts to deliver work on the Trojena ski resort and The Line city as the Neom project in Saudi Arabia stalls.

Steel company Eversendai announced this week that its structural steel contract for Neom's Trojena ski village, which is under construction in Saudi Arabia's mountainous Tabuk region, had been terminated.

Italian contractor Webuild also announced the cancellation of its contract to build three dams for a lake at the resort.

Hyundai Engineering and Construction recently said that its contract with Samsung Construction and Trading and contractor Archirodon to construct a tunnel for The Line was cancelled.

The cancelled contracts come as momentum on the Neom project appears to have stalled.

Trojena's cancelled steel contract follows news that it will no longer host the 2029 Asian Winter Games

Webuild was awarded the contract to build three dams for a giant freshwater lake at Trojena in January 2024, and two months later, the steel contract was awarded to Eversendai and Saudi construction company Al Bawani. The ski resort was initially slated to be completed this year.

The terminations follow reported construction de-

lays on Trojena and the news that it will no longer host the 2029 Asian Winter Games, which will instead take place in the city of Almaty in Kazakhstan.

Read:

"Neom promised radical urbanism but is delivering sterile desert suburbia"

Eversendai said that its work in the Middle East remains stable amid strikes across the region in the ongoing war between Iran, the US and Israel. However, it suspects that the conflict played a part in Neom cancelling its contract.

"Until the date of the notice, Eversendai had fully committed and delivered the project as per the contractual obligations with no compromise to safety and quality and we believe this has happened due to the current geopolitical situation in the Middle East," said Eversendai.

"Operations in the Middle East remain stable despite the current geopolitical situation," it continued. "We remain highly optimistic in securing more projects across the group to further improve our financial performance going forward."

A tunnel contract for The Line was also cancelled

Neom originally awarded its now-cancelled tunnel contract to Hyundai Engineering and Construction in June 2022.

It involved a 12.5-kilometre underground tunnel section that would form part of the transport infrastructure for The Line, a megacity that has been signifi-

Villa-Worthy Breakfasts We'd Actually Wake Up For

Julia Youman · Food52

If you've been around literally anyone in the past month, you've probably heard chatter about Love Island —whether it's the UK version or the ever-iconic USA one. Maybe you're all in. Maybe you've only absorbed it passively, against your will. Either way, it's hard to escape.

As someone who'd never tuned in before, I was surprised by the sudden cultural takeover. In the past few weeks alone, I've sat through full dinners where people debated their favorite couples, predicted drama, and ranked bombshells with passionate conviction. I finally had to get up to speed —if only to participate in what feels like a nationwide group project (slash networking event).

Over 40,000 civilian buildings in Iran reportedly damaged in ongoing war

Amy Peacock · Dezeen Architecture

Humanitarian group Iranian Red Crescent Society has reported that 42,914 civilian buildings in Iran have been damaged by US-Israeli airstrikes, including more than 36,000 homes.

Announced on X last week, the Iranian Red Crescent Society – a non-governmental group affiliated with the International Federation of Red Cross and Red Crescent Societies (IFRC) – calculated that US-Israeli airstrikes have caused damage to 42,914 civilian buildings in Iran.

This includes 36,489 residential units and 6,179 commercial units.

A number of cultural heritage sites have been damaged in Iran by US-Israeli airstrikes since the recent war broke out. Last week, the Iranian government announced on X that “at least 56 museums, historical monuments, and cultural sites have sustained serious damage”.

Among them is the UNESCO World Heritage-listed Golestan Palace in Tehran , which is thought to have been damaged by shock waves and debris from a nearby missile strike.

Historic buildings in Isfahan have sustained damage, including the Chehel Sotoon Palace, the Ali Qapu Palace and the Jameh Mosque. In Khorramabad, buildings situated near the buffer zone of the prehistoric Khorramabad Valley have been damaged, as well as the Falak-ol-Aflak Castle.

Read:

US-Israeli airstrike damages UNESCO-listed palace in Tehran

Iranian strikes have also caused damage to notable buildings across the Middle East. In Dubai, debris from an intercepted Iranian drone caused a fire at the Burj Al Arab skyscraper , and an intercepted missile caused a fire on the man-made Palm Jumeirah island.

Strikes in the Middle East have also reportedly caused damage to the White City of Tel-Aviv in Israel and Tyre in Lebanon , which are UNESCO-listed sites.

“UNESCO has communicated and will continue to communicate to all parties concerned the geographical coordinates of sites on the World Heritage List, the national Tentative Lists, as well as those under Enhanced Protection, to take all feasible precautions to avoid damage,” said UNESCO.

The current wave of strikes and counterstrikes began on February 28, when the USA and Israel launched airstrikes on Iran, killing Iranian supreme leader Ali Khamenei. Iran retaliated with missile and drone strikes on Israeli and US-allied countries and bases across the Middle East, and the war in the region is ongoing.

The photo is by the Iranian Red Crescent Society.

The post Over 40,000 civilian buildings in Iran reportedly damaged in ongoing war appeared first on Dezeen

Hot Honey Peach Bellini

Melissa Gaman · Taste of Home

3 medium peaches, halved

3 tablespoons hot honey

1 can (11.3 ounces) peach nectar, chilled

2 bottles (750 ml each) champagne or sparkling grape juice, chilled

Preheat oven to 375°. Line a baking sheet with a large piece of heavy-duty foil (about 18x12-in.). Place peach halves, cut sides up, on foil; drizzle with hot honey. Fold foil over peaches and seal.

Bake for 25-30 minutes or until tender. Cool completely; remove and discard peels. In a food processor, process peaches until smooth.

Transfer peach puree to a pitcher. Add the nectar and 1 bottle of champagne; stir until combined. Pour into 12 champagne flutes or wine glasses; top with remaining champagne. Serve immediately.

3/4 cup: 129 calories, 0 fat (0 saturated fat), 0 cholesterol, 3mg sodium, 13g carbohydrate (11g sugars, 1g fiber), 0 protein.

Dezeen Agenda features SOM-designed glazed towers for new Kazakhstan city

Saudatu Bah · Dezeen Architecture

The latest edition of our weekly Dezeen Agenda newsletter features a pair of towers in Kazakhstan by SOM. Subscribe to Dezeen Agenda now.

Architecture studio SOM designed two stepped, wedge-shaped towers to serve as a landmark for the new city of Alatau in south-eastern Kazakhstan.

Plastic bottles recycled into Parkinson's drug using bacteria

This week's newsletter also included news that University of Edinburgh researchers used bacteria to turn plastic waste into a Parkinson's drug, the Jewish history museum in Lithuania by LMA and a feature on whether the next starchitect could be a TikTok.

Dezeen Agenda is a curated newsletter sent every Thursday containing the most important news highlights from Dezeen. Read the latest edition of Dezeen Agenda or subscribe here.

You can also subscribe to our other newsletters; Dezeen Debate is sent every Thursday and features the hottest reader comments and most-debated stories, Dezeen Daily is our daily bulletin that contains every story published in the preceding 24 hours and Dezeen In Depth is sent on the last Friday of every month and delves deeper into the major stories shaping architecture and design.

The post Dezeen Agenda features SOM-designed glazed towers for new Kazakhstan city appeared first on Dezeen.

Adidas is bringing back its trefoil logo for the 2026 World Cup

Hunter Schwarz · Fast Company Design

For the first time in 36 years, the old-school Adidas trefoil logo will appear at the World Cup.

The vintage Adidas logo shows three leaf-shaped foils with three parallel horizontal lines that cut through the bottom of the shapes. It previously appeared on Adidas World Cup kits until it was replaced by the brand's triangular three-bars logo in the 1990s. Now, for the 2026 World Cup, the trefoil logo is making a comeback, appearing on the right chest of away jerseys for 25 countries, including Japan, Mexico, and Ukraine.

Bringing the old logo back is a nostalgia play. Sam Handy, general manager of football for Adidas, said in a statement that the German sportswear brand "felt it was a fitting and inspired moment to bring the trefoil back to the biggest stage in world football."

The kits pay homage to each respective country with local references, like florals representing local plants for Costa Rica and Chile, and a pattern inspired by artist René Magritte for Belgium. The revived logo instantly gives the kits a classic feel.

The history of the trefoil

The trefoil logo was introduced in the 1970s, when the brand was in expansion mode. Previously, Adidas had sold only shoes, and its first logo showed a track cleat with three stripes on the side and situated between the two extended

tails in the design in Adidas. When the company started selling apparel in 1972, it rolled out the trefoil created by German designer Hans "Nick" Roericht to symbolize a new era.

The trefoil stuck with the symbolism of the three stripes after founder Adolf Dassler put three stripes on the shoes for attention's sake as they showed up better in photographs. The trefoil's shape was inspired by florals, and the logo became a pop culture crossover after rap group Run-DMC's homage to the brand in the 1986 song "My Adidas."

The company modernized its visual identity in 1991 with its triangular three-bars performance logo, designed by creative director Peter Moore. It gave Adidas a more simple mark to better compete visually with the American brand Nike's iconic Swoosh, and it represented the company during a period of rapid growth in the 1990s and 2000s.

[Image: Adidas]

Today, Adidas shows how to use two logos at once, keeping its performance logo as its main mark while the retro trefoil appears on its Originals brand of casual sportswear and in nostalgic marketing campaigns. By bringing the old logo to one of the biggest global stages in sports, Adidas is looking to tap into the power of pre-Yeezy nostalgia for its vintage brand.

Hot Honey Salmon

Val Goodrich · Taste of Home

- 4 (4 to 6 ounces each) salmon fillets
- 1 teaspoon salt
- 1 teaspoon pepper
- 1 medium lemon, zested and juiced
- 1/3 cup hot honey

Preheat oven to 400°. Place salmon fillets on a parchment-lined baking sheet. Season with salt and pepper. In a small bowl, combine hot honey, lemon zest and juice. Brush over salmon.

Bake 7 minutes. Brush again with honey mixture and bake 7-10 minutes longer or until fish flakes easily with a fork.

1 piece: 354 calories, 16g fat (3g saturated fat), 85mg cholesterol, 677mg sodium, 24g carbohydrate (23g sugars, 0 fiber), 29g protein.

ANALYSIS

Strawberry Lemon Drop

Kate McKiernan · Taste of Home

- 3 fresh strawberries, sliced
- 1-1/2 ounces freshly squeezed lemon juice, plus more for the rim
- Ice cubes
- 1-1/2 ounces vodka
- 1/4 ounce triple sec
- Sugar, for the rim
- Lemon wheel or sliced strawberries, for garnish

Place strawberries and lemon juice in a glass; muddle until strawberries are smashed. Strain into a separate container, discarding the strawberry solids.

Fill a cocktail shaker with ice cubes about 3/4 of the way full. Add juice mixture, vodka and triple sec. Shake until the cocktail shaker is cold and icy on the outside, 15-20 seconds.

Dip the rim of a martini or coupe glass into lemon juice, then sugar to coat. Pour cocktail into the prepared glass. Garnish with a lemon wheel or strawberry slices, if desired. Serve immediately.

1 cocktail: 156 calories, 0 fat (0 saturated fat), 0 cholesterol, 2mg sodium, 12g carbohydrate (9g sugars, 1g fiber), 0 protein.

Why Meta is building its high-tech South Carolina data center with an old-school material

Nate Berg · Fast Company Design

In a greenfield industrial park in rural Aiken County, South Carolina, Meta is building a new \$800 million data center that's much like any of the other hyperscale data centers giant tech companies are scrambling to construct. Set on 300 acres with two massive data halls making up most of its 715,000 square feet of buildings, it's the kind of gargantuan facility that has become the de facto built form of the race to harness the lucrative power of artificial intelligence .

But past the sprawling data hall buildings, a comparably modest administration building has a unique design feature. Instead of the concrete and steel used in the data halls and countless other data centers around the world, the facility's administration building is being made primarily of wood.

[Photo: Meta]

A grid of honey-toned glulam mass timber beams and columns rise out of the dirt on site, and more wood tops the structure that's currently under construction. When the data center becomes operational in Spring 2027, this wood-framed building houses the offices of the humans who will keep the data center operational. And though the majority of the facility will be built using the conventional concrete and steel approach most designers and contractors are used to, this wood-framed building offers a glimpse of a slightly more sustainable future for data centers.

[Photo: Meta]

Mass timber is a material choice that has some clear upsides, especially when it comes to the negative optics of electricity-hungry, water-thirsty data centers. "Sustainably-sourced mass timber is a great fit for us because it has much lower embodied carbon than traditional materials like steel or concrete," says Blair Swedeen, Meta's global head of net zero and sustainability. (Meta has a goal of net zero emissions by 2030 .) "Using mass timber helps us build in a way that's better for the environment."

It also helps build in a way that can be much faster than building with conventional concrete and steel. Swedeen says using mass timber, which is typically prefabricated to the specifications of a project, can speed up construction timelines, saving several weeks. And with less overall weight than a conventional structure, the foundation for a mass timber building needs only about half as much concrete for its foundation. "The use of mass timber brought several positive changes to the project," Swedeen says.

[Photo: Meta]

The mass timber elements for Meta's data center project were provided by Smartlam North America , a leading mass timber manufacturer in the still nascent U. S. market. Nick Waryasz, a senior mass timber specialist at the company, says mass timber has been mostly used in residential

construction, but there's been growing demand for more industrial uses. "The biggest draw for using timber in those instances has been the sustainability metrics of building with wood when it's replacing steel and concrete, and having a team that has an interest in doing that, like some of these bigger tech companies," he says.

Amazon, for example, recently opened a mass timber delivery station in Elkhart, Indiana, which the company hopes to use as a proving ground for using wood in future industrial projects. A data center being built by Microsoft is also using mass timber for part of its structure. Other data centers, currently in a building boom , are likely to follow. And not just for environmental reasons.

"I've had some early discussions on big industrial projects like data centers recently, primarily driven by the fact of how long lead times are for steel construction," Waryasz says. "It'll be over a year out to get any kind of steel structures on projects, when our lead times for similar projects might be six months."

For the highly competitive AI industry, speed to market for data centers is increasingly important. That's why Meta founder Mark Zuckerberg announced back in July that one way it was accelerating data center rollouts was by using easily-built large-scale fabric tents . Mass timber could be a slightly slower but more permanent alternative.

[Photo: Meta]

Mass timber could also help soften the harsh image of some of these hyperscale facilities. "It brings warmth to things that sometimes are inherently cold," says Caroline Dauzat, fourth-generation owner of Rex Lumber , which provided the raw timber that Smartlam used to manufacture into structural elements for Meta's project. She says mass timber represents only a tiny percentage of what her company's wood is used for, but industrial projects could lead to growth. "It's a marketplace to create more demand for lumber."

Smartlam's Waryasz says the mass timber industry is maturing to the point where industrial projects like data centers may opt for mass timber products automatically. "If they continue at their trajectory or anything close to it, it might even just become a supply question, with timber for construction being relatively abundantly available," he says.

Meta's use of mass timber on the data center project in South Carolina is just a small portion of the facility's massive footprint, but future projects may embrace the material in a bigger way.

"We're continuing to actively explore mass timber not only in our administrative buildings but also in warehouses and critical data halls, the spaces that house servers," says Meta's Swedeen. "Mass timber's strength, durability, and fire resistance makes it a promising candidate for broader applications within data center infrastructure and we continue to evaluate these opportunities."

Other data centers, currently in a building boom , are likely to follow.

Nate Berg

You might be stuck in TSA lines for hours. Make sure you have these travel gadgets with you

Michael Grothaus · Fast Company Design

As the government shutdown drags on, having devastating effects on Transportation Security Administration staffing, millions of Americans continue to face long lines at TSA checkpoints at airports nationwide. With the busy Easter holiday travel weekend around the corner, wait times are expected to worsen as the number of travelers increases.

If you have a flight scheduled in the days ahead, here are some travel gadgets that can help make your TSA wait times more bearable.

[Photo: faraktinov/Adobe Stock]

Battery packs for long TSA lines

Thanks to modern smartphone batteries, which can last a day or more, you ordinarily don't have to worry about your phone running out of juice if you have a direct flight between any two points in the continental United States. But given that many airports are now advising you to get to the airport hours earlier to get through the long TSA checkpoints in time to make your flight, you may be risking a dead phone well before reaching your destination.

If you are planning to watch videos or surf the web on your phone to pass the time spent in TSA lines, make sure you have a battery pack, also known as a power bank, with you. If you're traveling alone, even a smaller power bank (around 5,000 mAh capacity) will be fine. But if you are traveling with others, a larger power bank (around 20,000 mAh capacity) that can charge multiple devices at once is better.

However, keep in mind that while the TSA allows power banks in checked baggage, the Federal Aviation Administration generally limits power banks aboard aircraft to those rated 100 watt-hours (Wh) per battery (about 27,000 mAh) or lower.

[Photo: Tramora]

Luggage with smartphone or laptop mounts

Speaking of using your devices to pass the time in the TSA line, holding your phone in front of you for hours on end can get exhausting. Whipping out your laptop is even more of a struggle. So why not give your arm a rest and let your luggage do the holding for you?

Several manufacturers now make luggage with built-in smartphone and laptop stands. These stands essentially turn your luggage into a desk that supports your device, giving your arms a rest. One popular luggage with a built-in laptop stand is the Tramora CABIN – T7. If you're just looking for smartphone support and don't feel like buying new luggage, there's no shortage of smartphone luggage handle mounts on sites like Amazon.

[Photo: Giraffe Creation/Amazon]

Collapsible stools

Even if you use one of the above gadgets to spare your arms while waiting in long TSA lines, your legs still face their own issues—holding you up. That's where collapsible travel stools come in. They are small, sturdy, and highly portable, and great for giving your legs a rest when you are standing stationary in TSA lines for hours.

The telescoping stools generally extend to about 17 inches high and can collapse into a film canister-like format with a thickness of just a few inches. Most collapsible stools can support hundreds of pounds—some advertise up to 400-pound thresholds. Pair a collapsible stool with luggage that has a laptop stand, and you'll have a nearly desk-like setup you can work from while your TSA line slowly advances.

[Photo: Xnmbcre/Amazon]

Portable travel fans

While spring has only just arrived, and in many parts of the country the summer heatwave is still a few months away, waiting in stagnant, crowded spaces can still significantly increase ambient air temperature, regardless of climate controls.

That's why it may be worth bringing a portable travel fan, especially if you already tend to get hot in crowded spaces. Many modern travel fans are small and collapsible, making them easy to travel with. They are also relatively silent, which means they won't be an annoyance to the hundreds of other people standing in line with you.

Most portable travel fans can be purchased for less than \$20, and many even have USB-C ports, so they can be charged from the same power bank that charges your phone. Speaking of your phone, you can even find a fan that plugs into your Android or iPhone, so you can browse the web and stay cool as the TSA line you're stuck in slowly inches forward.

The Best Italian Dictionaries For English Speakers: Apps, Bilingual Options And More

Thomas Devlin · Babbel Tech Blog

It's never been easier to get a quick translation of an Italian word you don't recognize. While being able to instantly look up an unknown term is great in a pinch, it's not necessarily the best for someone trying to learn Italian. Not only does relying on translators make it easier to avoid really understanding what people are saying, but also, the first results in a search engine will likely give you a translation with no context. To really dig into Italian, you should consider a more detailed resource: That's right, the dictionary.

We're not suggesting you lug around a massive tome — though physical dictionaries offer many benefits — instead, we're pointing you toward a few online resources that will help you out. We say “a few” because, like tools in a toolbox, each Italian dictionary serves a different need.

The Best Italian Dictionaries For Language Learners

Best Bilingual Dictionary For Italian Learners: WordReference

WordReference isn't exclusively for Italian, but there's a reason it's been relied on by countless language students over the years. It provides translations, as well as conjugations, example sentences and “compound forms” (phrases where the word appears). Another great feature of WordReference is their forum, where users discuss various Italian and English phrases to figure out how to translate them or explain them. This is helpful, because even the most complete dictionary might leave you with questions about word usage that a native speaker might be able to answer.

Best Dictionary App: Linguee

A good dictionary app is invaluable when you're on the go, and Linguee's design puts it ahead of many other options. The app quickly gives you results for possible translations, but also allows you to dive deeper into the word and how it's used in a sentence. This gives it a leg up over instant translators, because you can more easily tell if the translation makes sense for what you're trying to say. Plus, the app allows you to download dictionaries, so you can still use it even if you're not able to connect to Wi-Fi.

Best Italian-Italian Dictionary: Treccani

Once you've started feeling a bit comfortable in your learning journey, it might be time to switch from an English-Italian Dictionary to an Italian-Italian one. That way, you're not constantly switching between two languages in your head. If you want to go to the most authoritative source, then you'll want Treccani. Admittedly, Treccani's website can be a bit overwhelming at first, but it's filled with useful information on words, their histories and how they're used.

Best Dictionary to Learn Slang: Slangopedia

Italian is filled with a rich diversity of vernacular and colloquial phrases, largely thanks to the variety of dialects spoken throughout the country. While official dictionaries are great, they're very slow to adopt slang terms. Slangopedia, a crowdsourced online resource for Italian terms, makes up for that by collecting hundreds of words that are either new or being used in new ways. Admittedly, it's a little outdated at this point — the last updates are from the middle of the 2010s — but it still presents an interesting assembly of vocabulary you might not see anywhere else.

The Right Italian Dictionary Makes All The Difference

Choosing the right dictionary is about finding a tool that supports the way you actually learn.

Whether you prefer a traditional print Italian dictionary, a sleek app, or an electronic reference you can carry anywhere, the best option is the one you'll consistently use. A good dictionary doesn't just offer a basic translation of a word. It gives context, usage notes, pronunciation, example sentences and the kind of information that helps you truly understand how Italian works.

For beginners, bilingual dictionaries — especially an English-Italian or Italian-English edition — make it easy to move between English and Italian without feeling stuck. If you're looking up a word from English to Italian, you'll want clear, accurate Italian translations, plus guidance on which meaning fits your situation. A strong bilingual dictionary will also include common phrases, idioms and the occasional tricky verb form so you don't misinterpret an everyday expression.

More advanced students may prefer a more comprehensive Italian-only dictionary. These versions help you think directly in Italian instead of mentally translating back into English. That shift can be essential if your goal is to get comfortable using Italian naturally — whether you're preparing for travel in Italy, studying at college, or simply expanding your vocabulary in a new foreign language.

Digital tools add another layer of convenience. An online platform or mobile app can let you hear a native-speaker recording, check a phonetic guide to pronounce the word, and even explore related forms. Some apps also let you download entries for offline access, which is super convenient when Wi-Fi isn't available. Just remember to review the rating and privacy policies before you commit — not every flashy interface guarantees good content or solid privacy protection.

Print options still have their place, too. A well-designed Italian dictionary with clear layout, readable text, helpful color coding and easy navigation can be surprisingly lightweight and practical. Many learners like the tactile experience and fewer distractions compared to an app. A trusted publication like Collins, for example, often provides reliable definitions, consistent formatting and carefully edited entries — which can give you confidence that the information you're getting is accurate.

Brick Bonds book celebrates “the skill and craft of bricklaying”

Lizzie Crook · Dezeen Architecture

Graphic designer Melissa Price shines a light on the anatomy of the humble brick and the variety of bricklaying techniques used in construction in her book *Brick Bonds*.

Printed to the dimensions of a standard UK brick, the book was designed and printed by Price as a guide that illustrates “the full range of bonds in a simple form”.

It follows 10 years of research into the history of bricklaying and the wide range of bond patterns, which she feels are often overlooked or written about in a highly technical way.

Melissa Price has created the *Brick Bonds* book

“The subject matter for my personal work is driven by an interest in the potential of graphic design to reveal beauty in the normally overlooked,” Price told Dezeen.

“My research has led me to really appreciate the skill and craft of bricklaying,” she continued.

“The language of bricklaying is beautiful – there’s a rich lexicon, from the names of the surfaces of bricks, such as ‘stretcher’ and ‘sailor’, to the bond names, such as ‘rat trap bond’ and ‘quarter staggered bond’ and a personal favourite, ‘nogging’, which is a way of using brick patterns as infill between timbers on half-timbered buildings.”

It is designed to reveal the “beauty in the normally overlooked”

Price, who is a graphic designer at London design studio Cartlidge Levene, decided to create the book after working on a series of needlepoint-stitched artworks 15 years ago that were based on brick bonds.

“I stitched a number of different brick bond patterns in simple red and white, and through researching for that, I noticed the beauty in the variations of the bonds as well as the names and felt it was worth exploring further as a subject area,” she explained.

It illustrates numerous different brick bonds

Brick Bonds is Swiss-bound to ensure it can lie flat, facilitating use as a reference book. Its red binding is exposed, emulating mortar and referencing “the structural nature of bricks”.

Red hues were chosen as the dominant colour throughout the 96-page publication in a nod to traditional red brick, including the darker tone of the textured brick-like front cover.

Read:

Richard Rogers book teaches kids “the role of buildings in their lives”

The book begins with an overview of the anatomy of a brick before honing in on the different kinds of brick bonds and patterns. The first two sections focus on wall bonds and paving bonds. Generally, vertical structures use wall bonds, while paving bonds are for horizontal surfaces – though there is overlap.

The final two sections illustrate diaper patterns, which are those formed from different-coloured bricks, and finally decorative patterns, which are used to create texture rather than a flat surface.

The book also explores decorative patterns

These are all visualised as clearly as possible, with a half-page illustration and the name positioned above.

Price’s highlight of the book is the decorative techniques section, and her favourite pattern that she discovered is dogtoothing.

“Dogtoothing involves rotating the bricks 45 degrees in the wall so that the corners protrude, creating a beautiful texture that works so well with light and shadow,” she said.

“There’s a fantastic expanse of dogtooth bonded wall in the main hall at Haggerston School, a secondary school in Hackney, designed by Erno Goldfinger.”

Its binding is exposed to evoke mortar

Price said she hopes the book will be enjoyed by members of the architecture industry, but also those outside of it. She said it could help non-specialists develop a greater appreciation for the built environment, but she’d particularly “love to come across a really battered copy on a building site”.

Looking ahead, Price is now hoping to dedicate some time to exploring arch-building techniques.

Other architecture books recently featured on Dezeen include a colourful fold-out architecture book for children that showcases the work of architect Richard Rogers and a publication by Tadao Ando that collects drawings and models produced across his career.

The post *Brick Bonds* book celebrates “the skill and craft of bricklaying” appeared first on Dezeen.

Price's highlight of the book is the decorative techniques section, and her favourite pattern that she discovered is dogtoothing.

Lizzie Crook

Is Miraval Arizona – An Adults Only Retreat Resort Worth It?

Kristin Addis · Be My Travel Muse

I've stayed at a lot of luxury properties over the years — from tropical beach resorts to alpine lodges — but Miraval Arizona is in its own category. It's not just a place to sleep and eat well. It's designed to slow you down, challenge you a little, and send you home feeling like you actually stepped out of your routine for a few days.

Tucked into the Sonoran Desert just outside Tucson, the setting alone is enough to reset your nervous system. The mountains glow pink at sunset, the air is dry and warm, and everything about the property feels intentionally quiet.

Miraval is part of the Hyatt portfolio, and it's one of the places where Hyatt points can unlock an experience that would otherwise be quite expensive.

In my case, I booked the stay using a combination of Hyatt points and a Hyatt Privé rate — which ended up working out perfectly.

Miraval isn't a typical luxury resort where the goal is to lounge by the pool all day, though there are beautiful pools if that's what you want.

Instead, the experience revolves around activities, wellness programming, and time spent outdoors.

Each day you can choose from dozens of options, like:

Yoga and meditation classes

Guided hikes in the desert

Sound healing sessions

Equine therapy experiences

Fitness classes and workshops

Culinary demonstrations

Some activities are included, while others require additional credits or fees. The schedule is packed enough that you could easily fill every hour of the day if you wanted to.

But you don't have to.

One of the things I appreciated most about Miraval is that it doesn't pressure you into being constantly productive about your wellness. Some guests are running from class to class. Others are reading by the pool all afternoon. Both approaches fit perfectly.

Rooms and the Upgrade I Received

Miraval accommodations are designed to be peaceful and understated rather than flashy.

When I booked my stay, I used a combination of Hyatt points and a Hyatt Privé rate, which is a partner program Hyatt offers through select travel advisors (if you're interested in a Hyatt Privé, booking, get in touch as I'm an advisor).

Even though the stay involved points, the Privé booking still allowed the hotel to prioritize my reservation for upgrades, and I ended up receiving a really lovely room upgrade upon arrival.

That said, I wish I'd opted for a room with a mountain view. I went for the lowest category and I think an upgrade from a mountain view room to a suite would have been even more amazing.

The Setting: The Sonoran Desert at Its Best

The property sits in a beautiful stretch of the Sonoran Desert with the Santa Catalina Mountains rising behind it just outside of Tucson, right at the bottom of Arizona, meaning winters are mild and summers are HOT. I visited in February and though there was some desert rain, it didn't bother me at all and added to the coziness of the experience.

This landscape has a very specific energy. It's quiet, open, and full of subtle colors — soft greens from the cacti, deep rust tones in the rocks, and golden light that seems to last forever in the evenings.

Sunrise hikes quickly became one of my favorite parts of the stay. Watching the desert slowly wake up while the mountains catch the first light is one of those simple experiences that feels grounding.

The Food (Which Is Surprisingly Good)

One concern people sometimes have about wellness resorts is the food.

You imagine tiny portions of quinoa and kale.

Miraval does focus on nutritious, balanced meals, but the food here is varied and although the breakfast and lunch were fine — nothing out of this world — the dinners were truly delicious.

The approach is more about thoughtful ingredients and balanced cooking rather than strict dieting.

It never felt restrictive.

The Spa and Wellness Experiences

The Life in Balance Spa is one of the highlights of the property.

Like the rest of Miraval, it's designed around calm spaces and desert views. There are indoor and outdoor relaxation areas, quiet pools, steam rooms, and a long list of treatments inspired by different wellness traditions.

The sights and sounds of Bhutan

Tim Urban · Wait But Why

Ever present in my mind is The List: the countries I still haven't gone to that I most want to visit.

Ethiopia is on The List. So is Indonesia. And South Korea. And Madagascar. And Taiwan.

Early on, my wife and I pledged to visit two new countries every year, and we mostly pulled it off. Then came Covid, followed by two babies, and we fell off the wagon.

This year we remembered that we were gonna die at some point and decided it was time to get things going again. We dusted off The List, picked a country that's been at the very top for years, tossed the kids to the grandparents for a week, and headed off to Bhutan. ¹

Bhutan, if you're not familiar, is a tiny 800,000-person country squashed between two behemoths.

Bhutan was unified in the 17th century after millennia of existing as a collection of warring tribes. In the time since then, it has somehow avoided being annexed by China or India. Today, it is the world's last Buddhist kingdom, and I can confirm that it is both very Buddhist and very kingdom-y. Temples are everywhere, and the people are highly superstitious—our tour guide seemed to constantly be remarking about good luck and bad luck, promising omens and inauspicious riverbends. (The temples are beautiful, but so are all the other buildings. All architecture in the country, from the airport to the shopping centers, has a uniform Bhutanese style.)

The king is universally beloved and, at least the way they tell it, an exemplary ruler. A typical story we heard: 50,000 people work in the country's tourist industry, all of whom were suddenly out of work during Covid. So the king gave these families \$120/month, enough to get by on until the industry came back. He paid this out of his own pocket, nearly to the point of personal bankruptcy.

(Of course, I was also told in North Korea that it was only by the grace and courage of their magnanimous leaders that the people were prosperous and free, unlike their unfortunate South Korean cousins suffering under American occupation. But the situations are wildly different and I am inclined to mostly believe what I heard in Bhutan.)

One more story to illustrate what a sweetie Bhutan is: The country has a strict policy against killing animals and never euthanizes stray dogs, so there are a lot of them. They mostly live off the detritus of restaurants and hotels. When everything shut down during Covid, the king told people to bring cooked food out to the dogs and even wrap them in blankets during the cold months.

Bhutan does things differently than other countries. Hell-bent on preserving their traditional way of life, TV and internet were banned in the country until 1999, and if it

weren't for the cars, I might have been convinced I had taken a time machine back to the 1600s. Tourism is limited, only possible in the form of a guided tour, and immigrating to the country is near impossible. They are so diligent about conservation that Bhutan is the world's one carbon-negative country—their vast forests absorb more CO₂ than their populace emits.

In 1972, Bhutan's king decided that Gross National Happiness was a more important metric than Gross Domestic Product, and their policies cater to this value. ² It's why Bhutan is famous for supposedly being the world's happiest country, which I had no way to verify, but the people were very kind and seemed pretty happy I guess?

Sadly, Bhutan's way of life is threatened now as many of its young people have left to find opportunity elsewhere. The king is attempting to fix this with plans to construct Gelephu Mindfulness City, an economic hub which will center around innovation, while preserving Bhutanese tradition. It looks like it'll be incredible, though I was told not to hold my breath as it will probably not be finished for 20 more years.

All of this is to say that Bhutan is a special place—remote, mysterious, and breathtakingly beautiful. Which is why it was always prominently on The List.

A trip to Bhutan is better shown than told, so I kept most of the details to this video :

More posts from The List: [Siberia](#) [Tokyo](#) [Nigeria](#) [Iraq](#) [Greenland](#) [North Korea](#) And [The genie question](#)

If you like Wait But Why, sign up for our email list and we'll send you new posts when they come out.

To support Wait But Why, visit our [Patreon page](#). (During this book-writing phase, I've been doing mini-posts every Friday for patrons.)

It is not quick to get from Austin to Bhutan. We had to get there by way of Chicago, Zurich, and Delhi. ↩

In 2011, the UN passed a resolution being like, "all of you other shitty countries should consider focusing on Gross National Happiness too." Everyone appears to have ignored them. ↩

The post The sights and sounds of Bhutan appeared first on Wait But Why.

AIA sues Donald Trump over Kennedy Center renovation in unprecedented coalition

Ben Dreith · Dezeen Architecture

US organisations the American Institute of Architects and Docomomo US are among the plaintiffs in a lawsuit suing US president Donald Trump over his proposed renovations for the Edward Durell Stone-designed Kennedy Center.

Eight plaintiffs submitted a lawsuit this morning in an attempt to pause proposed renovations to the John F Kennedy Center for the Performing Arts in Washington DC.

The plaintiffs include the American Institute of Architects (AIA), Docomomo US, the Cultural Landscape Foundation, the American Society of Landscape Architects, the Committee of 100 on the Federal City, DC Preservation League, the National Trust for Historic Preservation and the Society of Architectural Historians.

Unprecedented coalition of preservationists

According to the group of plaintiffs, the lawsuit represents one of the largest legal coalitions of preservation bodies in history.

“No plaintiff can remember an instance in which so many national and regional organisations have coalesced to defend a single historic building and its grounds, reflecting both the Kennedy Center’s significance and the breadth of concern that the administration’s approach could weaken longstanding federal protections for historic sites nationwide,” said the plaintiffs.

Named as defendants in the lawsuit are president Donald Trump in his capacity as chair of the Board of Trustees of the Kennedy Centre, the Smithsonian Institute, the National Capital Planning Commission, as well as other government organisations and officials.

“It’s not about the president’s tastes. It’s about the rule of law”

The lawsuit contends that the administration must adhere to the processes in the National Historic Preservation Act and the National Environmental Protection Act before proceeding with planned renovations to the centre.

Given this, the plaintiffs demand that proper review and authorisations by congressional officials should precede any renovations. The lawsuit, if successful, would halt work on the structure until such authorisations and associated public reviews are completed.

Read:

Corinthian columns proposed for White House to match ballroom extension

“The Trump administration appears to believe that they can skip those federal requirements and go right to alterations,”

attorney and co-founder of Cultural Heritage Partners Greg Werkheiser told Dezeen.

Cultural Heritage Partners is one of the law firms representing the plaintiffs, along with Foley Hoag and Lowell & Associates, all of which have open cases against the administration relating to other preservation issues, such as the Eisenhower Executive Office Building, the East Wing expansion, and the East Potomac Golf Links.

“Each of these cases is not about the politics,” said Werkheiser. “It’s not about the president’s tastes, whether good or bad. It’s about the rule of law and doing what Congress intended.”

“I’m not ripping it down,” says Trump

Last week, the board voted to close the centre for years for renovations after voting to add Trump’s name to the centre, which was built in 1971.

On 13 March, president Trump released renderings on his Truth Social account, showing a building structurally akin to the current modernist building. In the post, the president said that the steel and some of the existing marble of the building would be maintained, saying, “I’m not ripping it down.”

Werkheiser said that the case is informed by the contradiction between the assurances given by the president about the East Wing and the reality of its demolition last fall.

“The hardest lesson for America to learn is that we cannot take for granted assurances from the White House,” he said. “For the East Wing matter, the President himself told the American public that to build the ballroom, the East Wing would not be touched, and then days later, it was gone.”

“So the lesson we’ve learned is timeliness and not to take those assurances for granted,” he continued.

Read:

How Donald Trump is using architecture to reshape Washington DC

Almost all the plaintiffs cited the historical significance of the building and the need for care and procedure in issues of its renovation.

“Architects have the core responsibility of protecting the health, safety, and welfare of the public and that includes the integrity of our nation’s civic and cultural landmarks,” said AIA president Illya Azaroff.

“The Kennedy Center is a public asset that must be shaped through transparency, expertise, and the communities it serves.”

In a statement to Dezeen, a White House spokesperson said that the administration is looking forward to “ultimate victory” in the dispute.

How to Spend the Perfect Long Weekend in Palm Beach—Like a Local

Kim Sunshine · Food52

Welcome to Like a Local, our series where writers share how to spend an ideal long weekend in their favorite towns. This time, Kim gives us an insider's guide to Palm Beach, FL.

What started as yearly visits to Palm Beach turned into biannual trips, and no matter how often I went, I always had a great time. It wasn't until I was lucky enough to get "stuck" in Palm Beach for months during the pandemic that I began to appreciate all this destination has to offer. Sure, it's gorgeous (like stepping into a Slim Aarons imagery time capsule), easy to get to (landing at PBI airport feels intimate, not intimidating) and its food rivals that of NYC and Rome. But living like a local made me appreciate all the nooks and crannies of this island. Here are my best bets for a perfect long weekend in Palm Beach.

Hot Honey Brussels Sprouts

Lindsay D. Mattison · Taste of Home

- 1 pound Brussels sprouts, halved
- 1 shallot, thinly sliced
- 1 tablespoon olive oil
- 1/2 teaspoon kosher salt, divided
- 1 garlic clove
- 1 cup lightly packed fresh parsley leaves
- 1 teaspoon grated lemon zest
- 1 tablespoon lemon juice
- 2 tablespoons hot honey

Preheat oven to 450°. Place an empty 15x10x1-in. baking sheet in the oven to preheat.

In a large bowl, toss Brussels sprouts, shallots, oil and 1/4 teaspoon salt. Carefully remove the baking sheet from the oven, and add the Brussels sprouts mixture. Shake to distribute them in an even layer. Roast, stirring halfway through cooking, until sprouts are tender and lightly browned, 20-25 minutes.

Meanwhile, place garlic on a cutting board; sprinkle with remaining salt. Mash garlic with flat side of knife blade, forming a smooth paste. Transfer to a large bowl. Add parsley, lemon zest, lemon juice and hot honey.

Toss hot Brussels sprouts with honey mixture until well coated; serve warm.

1 serving: 121 calories, 4g fat (1g saturated fat), 0 cholesterol, 276mg sodium, 21g carbohydrate (11g sugars, 5g fiber), 4g protein.

Chobani Just Brought Back This Fan-Favorite Seasonal Flavor Earlier Than Ever

Hayley Schueneman · Taste of Home

There’s no question that Chobani is absolutely crushing it with its coffee creamers. Every new flavor feels better than the last, and the product’s velvety texture makes for the most decadent cups of coffee. The only downside is that many of the brand’s flavors are limited-edition or seasonal, so fans wait all year for their favorites to return. (We even made a copycat cookie butter creamer to hold us over until it comes back.)

Luckily, one of Chobani’s best summertime flavors is back, and it’s back two whole months early. I guess they decided that this flavor is just too delicious to keep in the vault until June!

Which Chobani creamer flavor is back on shelves?

The beloved Chobani S’mores Creamer is back, baby! As a certified s’mores lover, I cannot emphasize enough how delicious this is. The combo of chocolate, graham cracker and marshmallow immediately evokes summer nights spent around the campfire.

Aside from the Confetti Birthday Cake flavor, this is probably the most popular of Chobani’s seasonal offerings. Except earlier this year, the brand announced that the Confetti Birthday Cake Creamer will now be a permanent addition to the lineup. Chobani ... does this mean the S’mores flavor could also become permanent? I think you should consider it!

How long will the creamer be available?

Typically, the S’mores flavor is released in early June to usher in the start of summer. So the fact that it’s hitting shelves in April is really exciting. “Early April” is all Chobani has shared, so it should appear on retail shelves in the next few weeks.

I have a theory about why Chobani bumped up the return of its S’mores flavor. Earlier this year, the brand announced a new “Flavor Drop” lineup with its most exclusive items yet. The first one was Raspberry Rose in February, and Chobani indicated that the next Flavor Drop would be in June. I’m assuming that the company didn’t want us to run out of room in our refrigerators by releasing S’mores and the new Flavor Drop at the same time.

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The post Chobani Just Brought Back This Fan-Favorite Seasonal Flavor Earlier Than Ever appeared first on Taste of Home .

Slow Cooker Masala Chicken and Rice

Taste of Home Editorial Team · Taste of Home

CHICKEN:

- 1 tablespoon butter
- 1 small onion, chopped
- 1 pound ground chicken
- 1 can (8 ounces) tomato sauce
- 1 cup water
- 1 teaspoon salt
- 1 teaspoon garlic powder
- 1 teaspoon ground cumin
- 1 teaspoon chili powder
- 1 teaspoon ground turmeric
- 1 teaspoon garam masala
- 1/2 teaspoon ground ginger
- 1/4 teaspoon ground cinnamon
- 1 bay leaf
- 1 cup frozen peas

RICE:

- 1 cup uncooked basmati rice
- 1-3/4 cups boiling water
- 2 tablespoons canola oil or butter
- 1 teaspoon salt

In a large skillet, heat butter over medium heat. Add chicken and onion, cook until no longer pink, 6-8 minutes, breaking into crumbles. Transfer to a 4-qt. slow cooker. Add tomato sauce, water, salt, garlic powder, cumin, chili powder, turmeric, garam masala, ginger, cinnamon and bay leaf; stir to com-

bine. Cook on low 4-5 hours. Add peas, cook 30 minutes longer. Discard bay leaf.

Meanwhile, preheat oven to 375°. Grease a 2-qt. baking dish. Add rice, water, salt and oil; stir to combine. Cover tightly with foil. Bake until water is absorbed, 25-30 minutes. Fluff with a fork.

Serve chicken over cooked rice.

1 serving: 491 calories, 20g fat (5g saturated fat), 105mg cholesterol, 1590mg sodium, 51g carbohydrate (4g sugars, 4g fiber), 27g protein.

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Grace Snelling

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